Dangerous Pie

By Jordan Sonnenblick

INTRODUCTION

Children have been taught since the beginning of time to love their siblings. Those "only children" out there, count yourselves lucky because loving a sibling is hard. *Especially when you have a brother like Jeffery: the cutest, sweetest, most embarrassing, and annoying child to ever walk the planet. "Dangerous Pie" by Jordan Sonnenblick*

I guess a good starting point would be the longest journal I've ever written in English class. This was back in September, when I was pretty sure about life. The topic was "The Most Annoying Thing in the World," and we were supposed to write the usual one-page response to it. I sat there for a few minutes, staring at the back of Renee Albert, who's the hottest girl in the eighth grade, trying to concentrate. Unfortunately, all I could concentrate on was Renee Albert. Did I mention she's the hottest girl in the eighth grade? Miss Palma is always going on and on about brainstorming and lists and "prewriting," so I started a list of truly annoying things:

.Journal assignments

. Dull pencils

. The pencil sharpener smell

. Miss Palma's perfume

. Why doesn't Renee Albert ever look at me? Hot girls who never look at skinny geeks

. Being a skinny geek

. Being a skinny geek named Steven

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Just then I realized that Miss Palma was standing behind me, reading over my shoulder (I guess that's why I was being asphyxiated by her perfume). Thinking fast, I covered up my list, turned to her, and asked, "Miss Palma, can the journal be longer than a page?"

Sure Steven. Why? What are you thinking about creating here?

("Creating here." She actually said that. Don't English teachers just slay you? My mom is actually an English teacher, but that doesn't mean I don't find my own English teachers a bit odd.)

Well, I'm having trouble crafting my prose. (Yeah, "crafting my prose." Two can play this game. . .)

What;' your topic! Remember what I always say; "F.F.F!" (Stands for "Form Follows Function," don't you know.)

Hmm…I want to write about a good topic…I want to write about…(And then it hit me. The most annoying thing in my

world is . . .)

My little brother Jeffery!

Anyway, here's what I wrote:

Having a brother is horrible. Having any brother would be horrible, I suppose, but having my particular brother, Jeffrey, is an unrelenting nightmare. It's not because he's eight years younger than I am, although that's part of it. How would you like to be King of the Planet for eight glorious years, and then suddenly get demoted to "Vice-King?" It's not because he's cuter than I am, although that's part of it too. I have mouse-brown cowlick-y hair, glasses that are about an inch thick and braces that look like I tried to swallow a train wreck. He has those

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perfect little-kid Chiclet-white teeth, 20-20 vision, and little blond ringlets like the ones on the angels you see on the posters in art class. It's not even because he hates me - he doesn't. The truth is that he idolizes me. And that's the problem: the kid follows me around like I'm Elvis or something. And while he's being much too cute and following me around, he also destroys all of my stuff, including my self-esteem and my sanity.

Take, for example, the "Dangerous Pie" incident. Jeffrey has known from an early age that the worst possible thing he can do to me is to touch my drum stuff. I have some rules about this: he may not PLAY the drums, he may not pretend the cymbals are shields and he is a knight, he may not hide IN the bass drum, and pretty much any Jeffrey-to-drumsticks contact is a massive no-no. But on one fateful afternoon last year, Jeffrey threw the rules out the window.

On the tragic day, I came home, said hi to Mom, glugged down some milk, and headed down to the basement to practice. I was in a particularly good mood, I remember, because Renee Albert had told me in P.M. homeroom that she liked my shirt. As this was such a grand occasion, I decided to take the Special Sticks down from their sacred perch and use them for my practice-pad warm-up. In case you didn't know this, a practice pad is a thick, dense, flat piece of rubber. Usually it's glued onto a piece of wood. You practice playing drums on it, because it feels a lot like playing on a real drumhead. Anyhow, the Special Sticks would be just an ordinary pair of my favorite sticks - Regal Tip 51's with nylon tips - except that they have been autographed by my all-time drum hero, Carter Beauford of the Dave Matthews Band. I once saved up all my babysitting money for a couple of months, got two tickets to a drum clinic Carter Beauford was giving an hour and a half away in Philadelphia, and begged my Dad to take me for two weeks until he

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finally gave in. At the clinic, during what I like to think of as "The Two Glorious Minutes," Carter Beauford himself called me up front to demonstrate a double-stroke roll. After I did it, he said I had "nice technique," and signed my sticks, right there in front of a roomful of drummers! So I had spent quite a bit of blood, toil, tears, and sweat in order to get the Special Sticks.

But the Special Sticks weren't on their shelf.

Jeffrey!

I ran upstairs at top speed, hoping I would be in time, but knowing that the odds were stacked against me. I burst into the kitchen and found Jeffrey doing his 'cooking' thing on the floor. Pots and pans were everywhere-don't ask me how I had somehow not noticed this on my way downstairs the first time-and Jeffrey was stirring some pretend concoction in the deepest pot of all. With my Special Sticks.

I advanced toward him, with what must have been a disturbing gleam of violence in my eye.

Jeffrey! Give-me-the-sticks.

But I'm just COOKING.

Give-me-the-sticks.

But the Dangerous Pie isn't ready yet!

I don't care about your stupid four-year-old make-believe food.

Give-me-the-sticks!

But it's REAL food!

And it was. Jeffrey's Dangerous Pie was a zesty blend of coffee grounds, raw eggs and their smashed shells, Coke, uncooked bacon, and three Matchbox racing cars.

The Special Sticks STILL smell funny.

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Or maybe I should tell you about the "Please kill me Mom" affair. This fiasco happened after my All-City High School Jazz Band concert last June. Getting into the All-City band is a big, big deal, especially for a drummer - because there are six trumpeters, five saxes, four trombones, et cetera, but only two drummers. It was even a bigger deal for me last year, because I was the first seventh grade drummer EVER admitted into the All-City high school band. They even had to send a special van to the middle school just to get me and this girl named Annette Watson, who's the backup piano player. She's actually really good, but there's this twelfth grade guy who's been the main pianist since he was a freshman, and he's not about to get booted by a middle school girl in his senior year. She's funny, and she may be the only kid in the middle school who cares about music the way I do, but she's also kind of weird. It's like she's figured out how to play Beethoven and Thelonious Monk, but hasn't quite mastered the art of being a girl yet.

It's not easy being the youngest guy in the band, by the way. They make fun of me all the time about my age, my size, my braces, and the way I stick out my tongue when I play.

Anyway, my whole family came to the concert, and it was AWESOME. I had this huge drum feature in this Brian Setzer song called "Jump Jive an' Wail" and I nailed the whole thing. I usually practice at least an hour a day on my practice pad and another half hour on my drum set, plus I play in the marching band and the jazz group in school, AND we had been rehearsing twice a week for All City for a couple of months, AND I used to take lessons once a week, so I was playing great that night. So after the concert, my parents and Jeffrey came to the band room. They were all excited and everything, but Jeffrey was bouncing off the ceiling:

You're a rock star Steven.

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No, I'm a JAZZ drummer Jeffy.

MY BROTHER IS A ROCK STAR! MY BROTHER IS A ROCK STAR!

Just then, Renee Albert stopped right next to us to congratulate her boyfriend (we'll just call him Biff), a sophomore guitarist with an alarmingly perfect complexion and muscles like Sammy Sosa. Jeffrey saw Renee, and started to whirl toward her-she lives around the corner from us, and I guess not even four-year-olds are immune to her charms and wiles. It seemed to happen in slow motion; events were just crawling. Yet still I knew I would never have time to run across town to the local zoo, steal an elephant tranquilizer gun, run back, and fire it into Jeffrey's buttock before he could blurt out something that would mortify me and destroy my social status forever.

Life snapped back into full-speed, and Jeffrey shouted: *Hey, Renee! MY BROTHER IS A ROCK STAR!*

As Biff looked on with a sneer, Renee replied:

Really? I didn't know that.

Yup, did you see his arms zooming around on the drums? It's just like when he practices in the mirror.

Steven practices in front of a mirror?

Yeah! He does it in his underwear. The blue ones. Right Steven?

I sagged against my mom's shoulder and muttered: *Please kill me, Mom.*

My dad tried at that point to control the situation, but by now Jeffrey had drawn a little crowd of my band mates, who were just waiting to see what else he would reveal.

My brother is GREAT! Hey, Renee, do you want to hear a JOKE? What does I-C-U-P spell?

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I give up.

Close the bathroom door! GET IT?

Dear Reader: Are you starting to see a pattern here?

Miss Palma gave me an "A" on the journal entry-she called it "droll" -so I guess I actually managed to get some use out of Jeffrey's antics before the chaos of this year started. Looking back on those days now, I'd have *eaten* the Dangerous Pie if I could have stopped October from coming.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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